

BEFORE

Advances in science and mass production techniques transformed the way people lived after World War II.

POST WAR

In the late 1940s and early 1950s the world was reeling from the effects of World War II << 392–405, but by the mid-1950s the mood was changing. The US experienced **economic growth**, as did Germany, France, and Italy. In Britain, food rationing, which had been in place since 1940, ended in 1954. Employment rose throughout Europe, and with it came the beginnings of a **consumer boom**.

90 PERCENT of all Americans owned a TV set by 1960

1 IN 3 families in the UK owned a car in 1959

NEVER HAD IT SO GOOD

In 1957 the British prime minister Harold Macmillan said, “Most of our people have never had it so good,” a sentiment that echoed around the developed world. People bought **luxuries and labor-saving devices**, developments in communication began to change the way people lived, and television took off as a mass medium.



ELVIS PRESLEY

ROCK 'N' ROLL

In 1955 Bill Haley and the Comets released the song “Rock Around the Clock,” unleashing a new musical style: rock ‘n’ roll. It was **music for a new generation**—teenagers—and it shocked older, more conservative

people. The greatest and most controversial star of the new genre was Elvis Presley.

BIRTH OF “POP”

Pop is **short for “popular,”** and in the 1950s it spawned Pop Art, which British artist Richard Hamilton called “**glamorous and big business!**”



Black Panthers March

An African-American civil rights group founded in 1966, the Black Panther Party marched for “land, bread, housing, education, clothing, justice and peace.” It became an icon of the counterculture revolutions of the 1960s.

The Sixties

The 1960s witnessed the rise of new forms of entertainment and a new political and social agenda. The changing attitudes to youth, gender, class, place, and race challenged the established order.

At the end of World War II in 1945, soldiers returned home and started the families they had put on hold for four years. This led to an unusually steep rise in the population curve known as the “Baby Boom.” In the United States alone, some 70 million “baby-boomers” became teenagers and young adults during the 1960s.

As the decade opened, it was a time of youthful optimism when anything seemed possible. And for the first time, the phrase “generation gap” was used. Where previously young people had aped their elders, new music such as rock ‘n’ roll empowered the younger generation, and adults were often left dumbfounded by what they considered the strange behavior of the youth.

Swinging sixties

In an age of increased middle-class affluence, the population had greater employment opportunities and a new buying power. In response to this, music and fashion became mass-market industries and were quick to cater to the demands of the youth market. The growing popularity of television helped spread popular

culture around the globe, so trends could take off rapidly. Programs such as *Top of the Pops* in the UK and the *Ed Sullivan Show* in the US made the 1960s swing to the beat of pop music. In 1962, the Beatles emerged from Liverpool’s Cavern Club. Their first album, *Please Please Me*, became famous around the globe within a year. They grew immensely popular, sparking such intense devotion in their fans that it became known as “Beatlemania.” At one time during the 1960s, they had the top five records on the US Billboard Hot 100 list, and the Beatles remain the best-selling pop band of all time.

Music groups provided the inspiration for fashion, from neat mod styles and blue jeans, to Elvis jumpsuits and the ethnic clothing of singers such as Joan

Baez. This fashion revolution burst onto the retail scene, led by designers like Mary Quant. Hems went up, then down. Adults found it hard to tell boys from girls. Both dressed in T-shirts and jeans; boys grew long hair; girls copied the model Twiggy by cutting theirs in a short “gamine” style. The unisex look had arrived. Boutiques sprang up to sell the new fashions, which were colorful, cheap, and informal. French New Wave cinema blossomed and also influenced style.

Permissive society?

Politics became more radical in the 1960s. There were many who felt that some laws were outdated and belonged to a bygone era. In 1966 the UK abolished the death penalty, and in the US support for the death penalty was

at an all-time low. Gay rights came to the fore, and in the UK in 1967 new laws were passed that allowed adult homosexuals to behave as they wished in private. Abortion became legal in the UK, and legal in some US states. But not everyone welcomed these changes. Some insisted it would make society more permissive,

or willing to accept what had once been considered “deviant” behavior. Others believed that these changes were the sign of a more tolerant society, willing to accept all people equally.

In 1963 Betty Friedan published *The Feminine Mystique*, reigniting the movement for women’s rights. Friedan and journalist Gloria Steinem challenged remaining areas of sexual inequality, giving birth to a wave of radical feminism known as the Women’s Liberation movement. More

Isle of Wight festival

Three music festivals were held on the Isle of Wight, situated off the south coast of England, at the end of the 1960s. The 1969 festival, shown here, was attended by 150,000 people. In 1970 it became the largest-ever music festival, with over 600,000 people in attendance.

INVENTION

THE CONTRACEPTIVE PILL

Before the development of “the Pill,” women all over the world used a variety of different birth control methods, which were often ineffective and sometimes dangerous. American nurse Margaret Sanger was a lifelong advocate of birth control and underwrote the research necessary to create the first human birth control pill, described as the most significant medical advance of the 20th century. Between 1962 and 1969, the number of users worldwide rose from approximately 50,000 to one million.

